

(Re)Making and Undoing of Peace/Conflict

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Eastern Mediterranean University Press

(Re)Making and Undoing of Peace/Conflict

3th International Conference in Communication and Media Studies, April 11-13, 2012

Faculty of Communication & Media Studies

Eastern Mediterranean University

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Eastern Mediterranean University Press ,2013

Famagusta, North Cyprus

ISBN: 978-975-8401-86-4

Cover Design: Serhan S. Çağlayan & Engin Aluç

Layout: Fırat Tüzünkan, Engin Aluç

Faculty of Communication & Media Studies

ISBN 9



9 789

The Use and Abuse of Sex Workers in North Cyprus: An Analysis of Mainstream News Media

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Women constitute a growing group composed of certain specific nationalities and ethnicities in specific sectors among migrants in the world. Cyprus has recently become a focal point of this growing regular and irregular migration and has been a destination country for women who are subjected to forced labour and forced prostitution ("Diplomacy in Action"; Göynüklü 2012). The recent flow of migration is described by Castles and Miller (2003) as a "globalised and feminized" one. From the migrant women's point of view, working in other well-off countries means having new occupational alternatives, getting relatively high income for low skill jobs, and most importantly escaping from severe poverty (Pravad 1999; Reynolds 1986 cited in Philaretou et al.2006, p. 106).

The first wave of migrant labourers entered South Cyprus in response to the labour shortage in employment sectors less popular with Cypriots (Matsis and Charalambous, 1993: 38 in Kontos, 2009)¹. Migrant female workers are coming from Russia, Bulgaria, Romania, Moldova, Belarus and the Czech Republic to work in Holland, Italy, Greece, Turkey, Cyprus and Lebanon (Philaretou et al.2006, p. 126). In Northern Cyprus, this took place after the socio-spatial changes in 1974 through the division of the island.

In the news article titled "First Time in the World"² (Boşnak 2010a) in *Kıbrıs* newspaper, it was stated that two young men had stolen two lambs from a neighbour's farm and gave them to

the manager of a night club to take two *konsomatris*³ out. Four months later, on 20th January 2011, we learn from the same newspaper about the young men found guilty of stealing and soliciting prostitution that "they might have done it before".⁴ In the same news article it is stated that the *konsomatris* were also found guilty (Boşnak 2010b). If *konsomatris* are taken out for sex with money and if they are caught or reported both sides are taken to the court.

In a news article entitled "Hit the booze"⁵ it was claimed that four women in Güzelyurt took two *konsomatris* from a night club. However, they were interrupted by police officers when one of the *konsomatris* reported them. In the following days it was revealed—in the light of the interviews with some of the Güzelyurt residents—that people wanted to know the identities of these women for the sake of their town's reputation. The news entitled "Such a relief"⁶ uses humor and infers that this news relieved the social tension. Journalist Tilki notes that Güzelyurt people are "corrupted" and ordinarily concerned about other issues, such as citrus and potato prices, debts and unemployment. Consequently, he asserts that some people are suffering from poverty while others are becoming crazy because of too much money.

These are the two news articles among many which are

1 Cyprus was a country of emigration and Greek (and Turkish) Cypriot women (and men) used to work in the textile industry as cheap labour in London (Phizacklea 1983).

2 "Dünyada bir ilk"

3 Although there are many words referring to this profession such as hostess, bar-maid, escort girl, cabaret dancer etc, the common term in use in North Cyprus is *konsomatris*. The word is coming from the French word *consommatrice*.

4 "Daha önce de yapmış olabilirler."

5 "Zevk-i Alem"

6 "İlaç gibi geldi"

enough to indicate that the sex workers and night clubs⁷ are a multidimensional issue in North Cyprus. The tone, the language and frequency of the news on the media are worth investigating since they also show the extent of social corruption, blindness and ignorance resulting from the night clubs and sex industry on the island. These news articles are also important to recognise how gender cross-cuts ethnicity, nationality and class (Agathangelou 2006, p. 12); and how sexism and ethnocentrism integrates otherisation and produces and reproduces “us and them” dichotomy.

Cyprus is one of the least migrant labour friendly and most exploitative countries in the world (OSCE 2006; Refworld 2012). According the UNHCR's Refworld report, “...women working in nightclubs and pubs who received ‘hostess’ or ‘barmaid’ work permits in 2011 came overwhelmingly from Moldova, followed by Ukraine⁸. Smaller numbers of women came from Morocco, Russia, Kyrgyzstan, Belarus, Kazakhstan, Turkmenistan, Kenya, and Paraguay. This area continued to be a zone of impunity for trafficking” (Refworld 2012)⁹. Sex work networks easily reached the former socialist countries that have been suffering from social corruption and poverty. Many women found themselves in this sector that expects low skills and high payment (Philaretou et al. 2006). Considering the importance of the issue it should be noted here that human smuggling (and trafficking) is the third largest source of profits after narcotics and arms. On a yearly basis 500,000 women are estimated to enter Europe (Kiatipis 2004 cited in Philaretou et al. 2006, p. 123).

This paper looks at the representations of migrant sex workers who might possibly be the victims of human smuggling and trafficking; and the victims of discriminative journalistic practices and discursive mechanism in mainstream media representations in North Cyprus. The divided status of the island has dominated the media discourse with political and public discussions around the Cyprus issue. Thus, the narratives, stories and thoughts of migrant sex workers are barely brought to the attention of the public, or they remain in the shadow of facts and figures, plans, regulations, policies and measures¹⁰. On the one hand both communities’ media see the issue as a symbolic, ideological and cultural border between them; civil society, by contrast, sees the

issue as an opportunity to collaborate for eliminating the from the island.

I have looked at the online version of the highest newspaper, *Kıbrıs* in North Cyprus. I examined news articles and commentaries starting from January 2009 till May 2012. The coverage includes news articles collected from news agencies and commentaries written by journalists. I also cover some commentaries from *YeniDüzen*, the newspaper with the highest circulation, and news taken from South Cyprus media such as *Cyprus Mail* and *Fileleftheros*. *YeniDüzen* gives space to commentary as well as news and it puts sex related news as a public issue but *Kıbrıs* tends to see them as individual stories which are not placed/positioned or referring to this social issue.

Night club (or cabaret) as a term connotes a place where male customers drink, dance and have sex with women as *konsomatris* in the Cypriot context. This different meaning causes confusion with some visitors to the island who attracts many tourists from many parts of the world. The common history of night clubs (or cabarets) in Cyprus. They used to be family entertainment venues 40-50 years ago in Cyprus. According to Philaretou (2006) a legislation reduced the number of female artist visas made it difficult for night clubs owners to hire big groups and variety acts. In the South, the nightclubs employ 1,100-1,300 women on artist's visas. The Cyprus Statistical Service and Immigration Department, estimates that there are 75,000 migrants in the country; 721 of them are refugees and 1,000 are undocumented workers in 2005 (Trimikliniotis and Souroulla 2006, p.: 21). In 2009 there were 58,000 legal and unauthorized foreign workers in Cyprus, making up 10 percent of the island's workers. The European Commission for Human Rights stated that the number of women in Cyprus with “artists” visa is very high considering the population (Trimikliniotis and Fulas-Souroulla 2006). It is estimated that there are 35,000 unregistered workers in North (Havadi, 2009, p. 7 cited in Güven-Lisaniler, 2005, p. 135).

The recent numbers provided by North Cyprus media show that 994 “hostess” and 21 “barmaid” work permits were issued in 2011. These numbers were 977 and 961 “hostess” and 14 “barmaid” work permits in the years of 2010 and 2009 respectively (Refworld 2010, 2012).¹²

In Cyprus’ case the demand and supply of women in night clubs (or cabarets) makes one consider the connection between sex work and human trafficking. The Cyprus Ombudsman Report on sex-trafficking states that women who are “artists” are living in desperate conditions and have been suffering human rights violations (Trimikliniotis and Souroulla, 2006, p. 29). The findings of some research

7 Although publications and others sources in the South refer to this “business” as cabaret, I prefer to use ‘night club’ since it is common in the North Cyprus media.

8 Ukraine is not just a sender country but also intermediary country. According to Philaretou et al 500,000 women left Ukraine to work in the sex industry. In some towns it is estimated that 95% of the girls are trafficked to Turkey and Greece.” (Hughes 2000; Kiatipis 2004 cited in Philaretou et al 2006, p. 126).

9 Refworld categories assigned to countries according to their conditions available for migrant labour. If the “TRNC” were assigned a formal ranking, it would likely be Tier 3 which is the last (and the worst) category. (Refworld 2012).

10 Although they are not a group included in this study, migrant women in domestic work constitute the second largest group in the island. It is stated that in South Cyprus Eastern-European (white) women are employed in night clubs or cabarets and Asian women are preferred as house-maid (Trimikliniotis, 2003; Panayiotopoulos, 2005; Agathangelou, 2005 cited in Trimikliniotis and Fulas-Souroulla, 2006, p. 9. According to KISA (2009) the number of domestic workers in the South reached to 27,000 (28.5 %) (p.4). In Northern Cyprus, in 2003, the largest group of migrant women with work permits was from Eastern European countries, which constitute almost half (50.7%) of the migrant women, and 86% of them were employed in night clubs as sex workers. The second largest group (46%) was from Turkey and worked at the casinos and low paid and low skilled jobs. (Güven-Lisaniler, Uğural and Rodriguez, 2008). Regarding domestic workers also see Aliefendioglu 2012, pp 495-496).

11 Some tourist guidebooks include a “polite” warning about such a poor understanding.

12 According to Güven-Lisaniler (2005) this number was 778 in July 2005.

North show that women working in the sex industry suffer human rights abuses at the hands of both the state and the employers (Güven-Lisaniler, Uğural and Rodriguez, 2005, 2008 and 2010; Prologue 2006; Göynüklü 2012). Furthermore, Refworld report also remarks that “Turkish Cypriot authorities did not conduct any anti-trafficking awareness campaigns during the reporting period” (Refworld 2010).

Sex workers are not just economically and sexually abused but they are pushed to the margins of the cities and public sphere both physically and symbolically. The location and the housing of the night clubs deliberately keep women outside the public sphere in the North literally in the middle of nowhere. Both in Northern and Southern Cyprus, the workers’ passports are kept by the police, the employer or the pimp. Action for Equality, Support, Antiracism (KISA)’s statement summarizes the real dimensions of the working conditions in night clubs: “The dependency that the migration model in Cyprus creates in the case of the ‘sex industry’, goes beyond slavery and is reminiscent of ‘concentration camps’” (KISA, 2009, p. 9) Göynüklü (2012) states that lack of legacies and many unknown and unreported aspect of the issue creates a highly worrisome conditions.

It is a known fact that some employers do not give their workers proper clothing for occasions other than night work (Esembe, 2005, p. 49). Anyone can see these *konsomatris*es with “odd” clothes at the airport, the supermarket and police stations with one or two pimps escorting them. Some people might think that this is the women’s choice however most of the time it is the employers’ promotion to present to the public the type of girls in service in the night club industry.

Prostitution is legal in South Cyprus; however some prostitution-related activities are defined as crimes¹³. Since it is illegal in North Cyprus, this explains why news reporting about sex workers is always crime related police stories¹⁴. Although *konsomatris*es are having sex with customers or forced to have sex, it only becomes criminal when it is done outside the night clubs or if someone reports it¹⁵. A study conducted by Prologue Consulting showed that male customers in the north do not know that prostitution is illegal in this part of the island. Consequently they do not believe sex workers could be victims of trafficking (“It is believed that prostitution is legal in the North”¹⁶). Although they are not supposed to work in prostitution, *konsomatris*es working in Northern Cyprus are

being routinely taken for compulsory check-ups for sexually transmitted diseases. In the event of a “positive” test result of either HIV positive or Hepatitis B, their employment permits are revoked, and the women are immediately deported (Güven-Lisaniler, Uğural and Rodriguez, 2005, p. 85; Kontos 2003, p. 53). The news article entitled “Blood sample is in Ankara” is about a *konsomatris* who had been hospitalised in North Cyprus on grounds of having tested positive for HIV. If her second (confirmatory) test result came out positive, the case would be sent to the court with a deportation order. It is worth noting that the name and nationality of the *konsomatris* was not revealed which is not always the case in the North Cyprus print media.

Refworld states that deportation is still “the most common form of ‘rescue’ the authorities use for women who complain about their employment at nightclubs and who ask for help from the local police” (2012)¹⁷. This application of a double standard, lack of language skills, and inexperience push women to the margins of legality, and prevent them from reporting and make them a dependence on their employers or pimps (Trimikliniotis, 2004; Malinova 1995 cited in Philareto et al 2006, p. 125). Refworld (2011) notes that there is a denial of sex worker’s human rights abuse in TRNC and no training provided to the police.

Existing patriarchal, sexist and ethno-centric values legitimize the exploitation of sex workers. These foreign women are seen simply as “prostitutes” and a danger to the moral values and integrity of the community. As Yücel puts it, “The attitude is that: well, they’re prostitutes anyway. They come here and break our families” (Trafficked Women Threatened with Torture in N. Cyprus). Ethnic nationalism on the island places unambiguous limits for women; Cypriot ethnic symbolic borders ease prejudices and discrimination against others for both their Turkish and Greek Cypriot ethnic purity. Migrant women are seen as a threat to the ethnic-national culture, family unity and moral values (Anthias 2006, p. 188) as much as women of both ethnic communities are represented as a “biological reproducers and signifiers of symbolic border of their ethnicities” as Yuval-Davis and Anthias asserted (1989, p.7). The simple fact that these women may be the victims of gross global human rights violations is simply ignored (Prologue 2006, p. 7).

Media Coverage

Many studies note that there is a serious lack of gender sensitivity in discourses and practices towards migrant women, particularly among the police and security forces (Badarevski, 2006, p. 19). According to Trimikliniotis and Fulas-Souroulla the media generally adopt a rather hostile and sensationalist approach to migrant workers in general and towards women in particular, spreading sexual stereotypes (2006, p. 9). Hadjipavlou (2010) also notes that a discriminative media discourse against Roma, Pontian Greeks, Russians and others is prominent in the

13 “Such as: (a) keeping, managing or assisting in the management of a brothel, the use of letting premises to be used as a brothel (sect. 156 (1) of the Criminal Code); (b) procuring a woman to be a prostitute or to work in a brothel (Section 157 of the Criminal Code); (c) detaining a woman against her will in a brothel (Sect. 162 (b) of the Criminal Code); (d) living on the earnings of prostitution (Section 164 of the Criminal Code); (e) a woman or man aiding for gain the prostitution of another woman (sect. 165 of the Criminal Code)” Trimikliniotis and Fulas-Souroulla 2006, p. 21).

14 TRNC Penal Code Articles 157 and 164 forbid prostitution and sex for money.

15 Pervin Gürlür from the North Cyprus Police Department, gave a speech on violence against women. She noted that when police catch anyone having sex, they can only be charged if they are doing it for money. (“Aman Duyulmasın”).

16 “Kuzey’de Fuhuş Yasal Sanılıyor” The article also states that this study has been conducted simultaneously by Prologue consulting and MIGS in both sides of the island.

17 For Dyer, where to send the victims when they are discovered –to prison or to hospital– is a very critical question (Basri-Akter 2011 p. 13). Some women might not necessarily go back their home country, but victimized again in the hand of traffickers.

mainstream media (p. 180). The (mainstream) media practices confirm the same attitude in the north.

The selection and content of the news and news making practices can tell us a lot about the social construction of the sex industry, how it “epitomizes essential gendering and socialization into polarized masculine and feminine behaviours, traits and attitudes” (Philaretou et al. 2006, p. 103). According to a survey conducted by Migration, Identity and Human Rights Center Studies Center, in March 2010, the primary social problems in North Cyprus are listed as lack of transparency in public administration, nepotism and ethnic discrimination. Other issues are a lack of tolerance to people of different sexual orientations and no acceptance of different ethnic people. Participants believe that human smuggling is an important global issue (61.8%) but the majority (89.4%) agree on deportation (“Public distrust is highest to political parties”¹⁸). I believe the discourse and framing of news about night clubs and *konsomatris* should be read and investigated in this socio political background.

All the news stories regarding night clubs or cabarets are scandalous crime or deviance stories mostly dealt with by the police and court processes about local men’s involvement in sex industry and sex workers and moral decline. The news article title “Raid against prostitution in Nikosia” in *YeniDüzen* announced the irony in the title. The news is about three young women who entered the island with artist visas, and who have been arrested along with three men. The decision of the judge was to deport the women since they violated their job contract. The news discourse does not make any difference between illegality of the perpetrators and the women themselves. One of the men, the owner of a night club said to the judge: “I pay 30 billion in taxes, everyone is doing this.”

Bourdieu suggests *habitus* as a system of learnt cultural dispositions of differentiated practices and mindset of people (Bourdieu 1993 cited in Lull 1995, p. 69). I am borrowing this term to apply to the media practices in North Cyprus. One common journalistic *habitus* in *Kıbrıs* newspaper, starting from the title, is that the usually crime-related stories about sex workers are told from the points of view of perpetrators, the men, the locals and the powerful as opposed to the viewpoints of victims, women, foreigners, migrants and powerless. The news article titled “They regret it” refers to a man who placed an order for a *konsomatris* from a night club, and to two others (one working in the night club, the other a taxi driver). All the names are disclosed, including the woman’s. “Miscalculation”¹⁹ refers to a *konsomatris* who asked for 300 TL for sex but got caught by the police and was sentenced to a fine of 5000 TL. The news titled “Sex Tourism Boomed”²⁰ ironically contains the result of a report on human trafficking. It can easily be observed that the night clubs and women employed there are scapegoated and the real anger of people directed towards these women as trouble makers who

are in fact possible victims of human trafficking. By doing the media and journalistic practices in North Cyprus encourage the public to put the blame on the minorities. They may be the contrary, be with the blamed, the powerless and marginalized in this controversy, which is beyond traditional impartial and objectivity.

Even in the case of death, *konsomatris* are not in the headlines. A news article states a *konsomatris* was freed on bail after she was travelling with a customer for sex, she lost her friend in a traffic accident, and the news article was ironically titled “She was on bail”.²¹ Two news articles by Çağda (2011a, 2011b) about an accident which caused the death of a *konsomatris* and two people injured were titled “He had no driving license” and “They will be taken to the police”²³. Although traffic accidents and especially ones with casualties are highly important in North Cyprus, they become ordinary news when casualties are women and *konsomatris*. For instance, there is no word on how many women working in night clubs who get killed in traffic accidents while local men are driving. In this sense news about night clubs and sex workers need a close reading to know these details.

The problem of sex workers and night clubs are referred to as part of social corruption in many columns, commentaries, interviews as well as the news. It is compared to other social issues such as the lack of municipal services, public health issues²⁴, citizenship, unemployment²⁵, personal debt and governance. Many journalists discuss this issue in relation to the existing government’s policies or Turkey’s political intervention. Night clubs are seen as the face of general corruption in North Cyprus. This standpoint is quite common in the left wing and liberal media in the north. Some female journalists share this view and they deal with the issue with sensationalized discourses and phrases like: “the cruel world in which they are living” or “their painful lives” or “their sad end”.

North Cyprus print media shows a global sensitivity to the issue in foreign news selection. A caption under a photograph

21 “Teminatla serbest”

22 “Ehliyeti de yoktu”

23 “Polise ifade verecekler”

24 Article entitled: “Cesur Milletiz” (We are a Brave Nation) by an unnamed Dr. Kezban Akyön from the Ministry of Health for international women’s day. She states that condom sales are in decline in North Cyprus. Dr. Akyön states that “women are very sensitive on the issue so that those who are diagnosed with HIV and AIDS and hepatitis B are immediately being deported”. Dr. Akyön also adds that “women in night clubs are tested for sexually transmitted diseases. They are being given a health check on a daily basis in small groups.”

25 A news article entitled “A desperate situation” (Tablo 1000) by an unnamed journalist with a psychologist about recent personal and social trauma in North Cyprus. The psychologist notes that unemployed people may end up with mental health problems by visiting night clubs, gambling and drug abuse.

26 “Case in point” (İbret Verici) is a news article about a man who committed suicide because of his casino and night club debts. This news article is a warning for “proper men” to keep themselves away from these temptations.

27 North Cyprus has remained unrecognized since 1974 when Turkey invaded the island following the conflict between the two major ethnic groups, which has created a specific relationship with Turkey. The news article titled “A banner in front of EU Building” refers to this unique tie and states that “the presence of trade unions in the North in their visit to the European Parliament has put the women issue into a broader picture: For them, Turkey in order to maintain its economic sources of income, has encouraged casinos, mafia activities, and the trade of women while the EU ignore this (“AB binası önünde bayrak”)

18 “En fazla güvensizlik siyasi partilere”

19 “Zararlı çıktı”

20 “Seks Turizmi Patladı”

"Photo world"²⁸ reads, "In famous brothels in Bangladesh a real human drama is being experienced. There are 12 years old girls." Although the media claim sensitivity towards the issue there is a contradiction between the text and visual images. Some news articles come with provocative visuals depicting the scenes in night clubs. Visuals either show women and men between police officers or naked women in the gloomy atmosphere in night clubs. As Göynüklü (2012) states "This issue has been covered by journalists, however, majority of these news stories covered in the media encourages the public rather than deterring them because of the photographs, the language used and generally the way it was covered".

Kıbrıs has a page titled "From the South"²⁹. This page can be read as consider this "inside-out"ness of foreign news in the North Cyprus print media. Moral interviews with Michaelides, the Priest of Limasol Orthodox Church, who opened a shelter where sex workers can stay ("I have saved 300 women"³⁰). Michaelides says that majority of the women who came to Cyprus have been cheated. They were told that they were going to dance and drink with male customers but never told that they would be forced to have sex with them. Once they entered the country it was too late for many of them. Michaelides also adds that sexual exploitation is not limited with sex, dancing for their customers and drinking with their customers should be regarded as a sexual exploitation. This reminds the reader that the shelter was not run by local authorities but it was left to a priest to initiate such a charity.

Here are some news articles taken from the Southern print media on the issue: "The south cannot prevent women trafficking"³¹ explains that the number of trafficked women dropped compared to former years but it is because the number of police operations dropped. According to the news 34 police operations in 2008 have dropped to 8 in 2009.

The news titled "We will close the check points"³² from *Fileleftheros* explains new visa applications for *konsomatris*es in the south which put a certain condition of educational attainment for women to work in night clubs. Night club owners threatened the authorities to block one of the check points between the South and the North. Night club owners "occupied" and stopped car traffic in front of the presidential palace ("Night Club Owners spilled into the streets")³³. As *Fileleftheros* puts it, women trafficking works like clock-work in the South ("Greek side cannot prevent women trafficking"). A year and half later another news article taken from *Fileleftheros* mentions official preventive measures: The Minister of Internal Affairs, Neoklis Silikiotis, announced that, between February 2009 and January 2011, 39 night clubs in the South were closed. The number of

night clubs where women are working dropped from 1200 to 228 in February 2011 ("Women Trafficking is being prevented")³⁴.

There is a growing pressure by civil society in Cyprus. The Baraka Cultural Center and The Human Rights Foundation note two dimensions to the issue. Lack of awareness in public and lack of legal regulation at the state level go hand in hand. Their activities and calls are very well received by the public. Those activities are not limited to particular days such as International human rights day or women's day. Occasionally many events and protests are carried out and many reports are published by the Mediterranean Institute of Gender Studies (MIGS), KISA (in South Cyprus), Turkish Cypriot Human Rights Foundation, Refugee Rights Association, Engelsiz (an initiative active on handicapped people's rights), Gender and Minority Institute, The Foundation for the Prevention of Social Risks (in the North). These are the organizations dealing with cases, and collaborating with authorities both in North and South Cyprus, and with many international organizations. In 2010, some NGOs and some leading women's organisations have initiated public protests to call for the closing of nightclubs where major women's human rights violations were taking place. Feminist Atelier (FEMA) with the collaboration of different NGOs recently have been coming up with the demand of closing night clubs by pointing out that night clubs are brothels ("They will march")³⁵. NGOs are aware of the public perception that women working in these night clubs are working voluntarily, however, it is their aim to make the public aware that those women could be victims of human trafficking.

In terms of media representation, there is greater coverage of the issue in South Cyprus. There are more frequent meetings, seminars and gatherings for equal rights for migrant women, likely, as a result of EU membership. In the news article entitled "Not enough is being done to address migrant women's needs" (Dewhurst, 2009), The Minister of Labour says "Most migrants to Cyprus are women and face a double discrimination based on gender and ethnicity". The ministry revised the contracts and employment policies for cabaret performers and women employed in bars and homes to improve their conditions of employment. News coverage in the South shows that there is an attempt of *gender mainstreaming* in labour and migration policies. The news articles related to the issue cover both official announcements and NGO press releases in the South. However media coverage in the North is limited to the declarations of voluntary organizations and public protests not by official authorities.

Closing Notes and Suggestions

As it has been shown, the media depicts the issue of sex workers as scandal-news rather than commentary or news focusing on a burning social issue. This indirectly contributes to the perception that this domain exists outside of the normal rules

28 "Foto Dünya"

29 "Güneyden"

30 "300 kadını kurtardım"

31 "Rum tarafı Kadın Ticaretini Önleyemiyor"

32 "Barikatları Kapatırız"

33 "Gece Klüpleri Sahipleri Sokağa Döküldü"

34 "Kadın Ticareti Önleniyor"

35 "Yürüyüş yapacaklar"

and regulations of society. This leaves an atmosphere with no legal regulations against human trafficking and any protective mechanisms and services or recourse for the victims. Racialized, sexualized, and even a hostile discourse in the media, keep the stories of sex workers and their "sexually suspect" behaviours out of sight, out of reach, and out of mind (Refworld 2011). In 2011, despite the pressure from civil society "Turkish Cypriot officials continued to fail to identify formally any trafficking victims, as no formal definition of 'victim' has been instituted" (Refworld 2012). This causes confusion between, prostitution trafficking and smuggling (Badarevski 2006, p. 232)³⁶ as there is no specialized training on how to identify, investigate, or prosecute trafficking (Refworld, 2012).

As Badarevski (2006) states in a study on analyzing the media discourse on the traffic of women, migrant men are described as "active, courageous, and adventurous spirits", while the coverage of migrant women portrays them as innocent, passive, incapable, irrational, immoral and victims of trafficking. But it should be reminded that migrant women either in sex industry or other sectors initiate an individual project of "escape from poverty" and deprivation in their home countries. (p.235). As Anthias and Lazaridis (2000) stated "women must be seen as active agents rather than passive victims" (p. 12) both by people and the media.

There are some pair studies in both sides of the island. However my analysis on news shows there is an urgent need for increasing awareness and raising consciousness about migrant women and sex workers in Cyprus. Media professionals should know that, as Göynüklü (2012) suggests, "The mix-up of the names and concepts of trafficking and prostitution is evident in the news stories and columns in the newspapers; these stories are usually handled by using the wrong images and the wrong language." Societal expectation from journalists and the media is not only limited with gathering news but also demands a fair hearing for all components of society. Journalistic practices in North Cyprus should engage with human rights, and human stories should be embraced by journalists. It would particularly be useful if the journalists shed off their insensitivity and lack of awareness to gender and human rights issues. Similarly, the media are abdicating an important part of their roles as public educators and peace makers by failing to bring this dimension to the public sphere, thereby perpetuating the idea that women are not victims but are prostitutes who pollute the local culture. The media should initiate a proactive role to be part of solution rather than maintaining the problem or magazinising and reducing it to public health issue.

36 Smuggling and trafficking are different concepts: Smuggling is illegal entry into a country, which is a crime against the state. However human trafficking is a crime against a person (see ICMPD for a detailed comparison). "Trafficking in persons" was first defined in the Palermo Protocols in 2000 during a conference. Official name of the protocol is the United Nations Protocol to Prevent, Suppress and Punish Trafficking in Persons Especially Women and Children, supplementing the United Nations Convention against Transnational Organized Crime. Council of Europe Convention on Action against Trafficking in Human Beings was opened in 2005 to non EU signatories (Göynüklü 2012).

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